GEC English – Language Summary

Grade 9 · Language structures and conventions – the short version

1. Parts of speech

Part	Job	Examples
Noun	Names a person, place, thing or idea	*girl, Paarl, table, love*
Pronoun	Replaces a noun	*he, they, mine, myself, who*
Verb	Action or state of being	*run, think, is, have*
Adjective	Describes a noun	*tall, red, happy*
Adverb	Describes a verb, adjective or adverb (how, when, where, how often, how much)	*quickly, yesterday, here, often, very*
Preposition	Shows position, time or direction	*in, on, under, after, towards*
Conjunction	Joins words or clauses	*and, but, because, although*
Interjection	Sudden emotion	*Wow! Ouch!*
Article	Points out a noun	*a, an, the*

Kinds of nouns	
Common / proper	*city / Cape Town*
Concrete (can touch)	*chair, apple*
Abstract (ideas, feelings)	*honesty, fear*
Collective (group)	*team, flock, swarm*

Kinds of pronouns	
Personal	*I, me, he, them*
Possessive	*mine, his, theirs (no ')*
Reflexive	*myself, themselves*
Demonstrative	*this, that, these, those*
Relative	*who, which, that, whose*

Verbs: auxiliary (helping: is, has, will, can) · **linking** (is, seems, becomes) · **transitive** (has an object: *kicked the ball*) · **intransitive** (no object: *slept*) · **gerund** (-ing as a noun: *Swimming is fun*).

Degrees of comparison: tall – taller – tallest · happy – happier – happiest · beautiful – more beautiful – most beautiful · good – better – best · bad – worse – worst · many – more – most · little – less – least. Never "more taller".

2. Sentence types

By purpose	
Statement .	*The bus is late.*
Question ?	*Is the bus late?*
Command . / !	*Close the door.*
Exclamation !	*What a goal!*

By structure	
Simple	1 main clause
Compound	2+ main clauses (FANBOYS / ;)
Complex	main + subordinate clause
Compound-complex	2+ main + 1+ subordinate

The cat ran away because the dog barked. → *complex (main + subordinate)*

3. Phrases and clauses

> **Phrase** = group of words with **no** subject + finite verb (*in the morning*). **Clause** = has a subject **and** a finite verb (*when the bell rang*).

Type	Job	Example
Main clause	Makes sense alone	*I stayed home because I was sick.*
Subordinate clause	Needs the main clause	*I stayed home because I was sick.*
Adjectival clause	Describes a noun (who, which, that)	*The boy who won is my brother.*
Adverbial clause	When, where, why, how, condition	*When the bell rang, we left.*
Noun clause	Acts as a noun	*I know that you are right.*
Adjectival phrase	Describes a noun	*The house on the hill...*
Adverbial phrase	How / when / where	*He arrived after lunch.*

4. Conjunctions

Kind	Words	Example
Coordinating	FANBOYS: for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so	*I was tired, so I slept.*
Subordinating	because, although, when, while, if, unless, since, until, before, after	*Although it rained, we played.*
Correlative	either...or, neither...nor, both...and, not only...but also	*Neither Tom nor Sam came.*

Meaning: **addition** (and, also) · **contrast** (but, although, whereas) · **reason** (because, since) · **result** (so, therefore) · **condition** (if, unless) · **time** (when, after, until). *However, therefore* join sentences with **; ... ,** → *It was late; however, we stayed.*

5. Tenses

	Simple	Continuous	Perfect	Perfect continuous
Present	I play	I am playing	I have played	I have been playing
Past	I played	I was playing	I had played	I had been playing
Future	I will play	I will be playing	I will have played	I will have been playing

Irregular verbs: go–went–gone · see–saw–seen · write–wrote–written · eat–ate–eaten · take–took–taken · begin–began–begun · drink–drank–drunk · swim–swam–swum · bring–brought–brought · break–broke–broken · choose–chose–chosen · fly–flew–flown.

Concord: singular subject → singular verb: *The boy runs · The boys run · Each of the boys is · Everyone has · The team is*.

6. Active and passive voice

> **Active:** *The dog (doer) bit the boy.* → **Passive:** *The boy was bitten by the dog.*
> Steps: 1. object becomes subject · 2. **be** (same tense) + **past participle** · 3. doer after **by** (or leave out) · 4. change pronouns (they → them, I → me).

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple present	Sam cleans the room.	The room **is cleaned** by Sam.
Present continuous	Sam is cleaning the room.	The room **is being cleaned** by Sam.
Present perfect	Sam has cleaned the room.	The room **has been cleaned** by Sam.
Simple past	Sam cleaned the room.	The room **was cleaned** by Sam.
Past continuous	Sam was cleaning the room.	The room **was being cleaned** by Sam.
Past perfect	Sam had cleaned the room.	The room **had been cleaned** by Sam.
Future	Sam will clean the room.	The room **will be cleaned** by Sam.
Modal	Sam must clean the room.	The room **must be cleaned** by Sam.

Plural subject → **were / are**: *The tests were marked.* Only verbs with an object can become passive.

7. Direct and indirect speech

> **Direct:** Lerato said, "I am tired today." → **Indirect:** Lerato said that she was tired that day.
> Steps: 1. remove " " and add **that** · 2. change **pronouns** · 3. move the **tense one step back** · 4. change **time and place** words.

Direct	Indirect
am / is / play	was / played
is playing	was playing
has played / played	had played
will / can / may	would / could / might
must	had to

Direct	Indirect
now / here	then / there
today / tonight	that day / that night
yesterday	the day before
tomorrow	the next day
this / these / ago	that / those / before

Type	Direct	Indirect
Yes/no question	He asked, "Are you coming?"	He asked **if** I was coming.
Wh- question	She asked, "Where do you live?"	She asked where I lived.
Command	He said, "Sit down."	He **told** us **to sit** down.
Negative command	Mom said, "Don't be late."	Mom told me **not to be** late.
Request	He said, "Please help me."	He **asked** me **to help** him.

No question mark in indirect questions. If the verb is **says** (present), the tense stays the same.

8. Punctuation

Mark	Main uses	Example
Comma ,	Lists; after an introductory clause; before FANBOYS joining clauses; around extra info; before direct speech	*When I got home, I slept.*
Apostrophe '	Possession: boy's (1), boys' (many), children's · Contractions: don't, it's	*it's = it is · its = belonging to it*
Colon :	Before a list or explanation	*Bring: a pen and a ruler.*
Semicolon ;	Joins two related main clauses	*It was late; we went home.*
Inverted commas " "	Direct speech, quotations, titles	*"Hello," she said.*
Dash – / Hyphen -	Dash: break / emphasis · Hyphen: joins words	*He opened it – and screamed. · well-known*
Brackets ( )	Extra information	*SA (South Africa)*
Ellipsis ...	Words left out, pause, suspense	*I was going to, but...*
Capitals	Sentence start, proper nouns, I, days, months	*On Monday, Ms Daniels and I...*

Direct speech: capital letter inside " ", end punctuation **inside** the closing ", comma before "said", new paragraph for each new speaker.

9. Spelling and plurals

Plural rule	Examples
Most words + **s**	book → books
s, ss, sh, ch, x, z + **es**	bus → buses, box → boxes, church → churches
consonant + y → **ies** · vowel + y → **s**	baby → babies · boy → boys
f / fe → **ves** (but roof, chief, belief + s)	leaf → leaves, knife → knives
consonant + o → **es** (but photo, piano, radio, zoo + s)	potato → potatoes, hero → heroes
Irregular	man → men, child → children, foot → feet, tooth → teeth, mouse → mice, person → people
No change	sheep, deer, fish, series
Foreign	cactus → cacti, crisis → crises, criterion → criteria, bacterium → bacteria
Compound – main word plural	mother-in-law → mothers-in-law, passer-by → passers-by

Spelling rule	Examples
i before e except after c	believe, piece · receive, ceiling (except: weird, seize)
Drop the e before a vowel suffix	make → making, hope → hoping (but hopeful)
Double the last consonant (short vowel)	run → running, stop → stopped, big → bigger
y → i before a suffix (not -ing)	happy → happiness, carry → carried · carrying
-ful has one l; all/well lose an l	careful · already, also, welcome

Often misspelt: accommodation, definitely, necessary, separate, government, environment, embarrass, occurred, beginning, receive, tomorrow, business, immediately, February, Wednesday, argument.